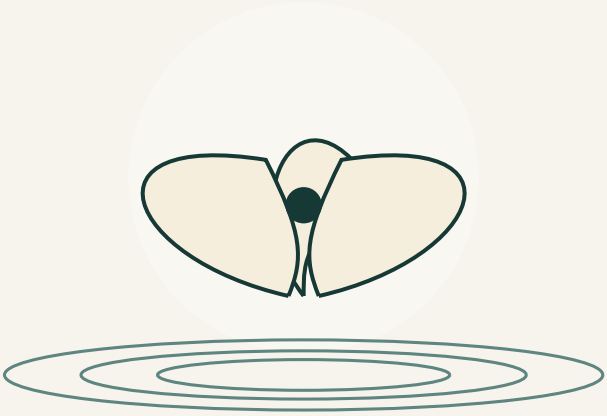
ILLUSTRATED READER'S COMPANION

The Buddhas and Bodhisattvas of the Samādhi Water Repentance

Stories, memorable facts, and pathways through Scrolls One, Two, and Three



A respectful, beginner-friendly guide to every named Buddha and bodhisattva in the English liturgy.

Prepared by Daniel Franjkovic
daniel.franjkovic@outlook.com.au

For all other glossary words: https://www.fgsitc.org/glossary/

EXPANDED COMPANION EDITION

Buddhas and Bodhisattvas

Stories, symbols and their place in the Water Repentance

Prepared by **Daniel Franjkovic**

daniel.franjkovic@outlook.com.au

Source edition

Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple, Electronic Edition 3.0, April 2022.
English translation, editing and design by Andrew Nguy and Raymond Kong.

This independent companion explains the source liturgy. It is not a replacement translation or an official temple edition. Source-page references count PDF pages; printed page numbers are given where useful. In communal practice, follow the officiant's instructions.

The original liturgies remain copyrighted by Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple and are linked in the references. New explanations and reading notes are clearly distinguished from source wording.

Further Buddhist terminology: www.fgsitc.org/glossary/

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Buddhas and bodhisattvas

A visual companion to the three scrolls

Most of the principal figures are introduced in Scroll One and invoked again in Scrolls Two and Three. Dīpaṃkara Buddha appears in the lamp praise that opens Scroll Three. Pronunciations are practical English approximations; they do not reproduce every distinction in Sanskrit, Mandarin or Vietnamese.

How to use these profiles

On a first reading, look for three things in each profile: **who the figure is**, **what the liturgy is doing by naming them**, and **which quality the name brings into repentance**. The story and artwork notes can wait until a second reading.

The labels matter:

- **Canonical account** means the story appears in a Buddhist scripture cited in the source trail.
- **Traditional account** means it belongs to a recognised devotional or narrative tradition, but the profile does not present it as modern historical biography.
- **Recognition cue** means an attribute often used in Buddhist art. Regional and historical forms vary, so one cue is rarely enough to identify an unlabelled image with certainty.

The Water Repentance invokes these figures as awakened teachers, witnesses and models of practice. Calling a name does not transfer moral responsibility to that figure. The practitioner still confesses, reforms conduct, makes vows and dedicates the benefit.

Four titles first

Title	Say it like	Meaning
Buddha	*BOOD-uh*	An Awakened One.
Tathāgata	*tuh-THAH-guh-tuh*	“Thus Come One”, a title of a Buddha.
Bodhisattva	*boh-dee-SUT-vuh*	One committed to Buddhahood for the benefit of all beings.
Mahāsattva	*muh-HAH-SUT-vuh*	“Great being”, an honorific for an advanced bodhisattva.

Relationships at a glance

Grouping	Who appears together	Why it helps here
Historical teacher and great attendants	Śākyamuni with Mañjuśrī and Samantabhadra	Wisdom understands the fault; practice carries the remedy into action. This is a common East Asian artistic grouping, although the liturgy also invokes each figure separately.
The two Buddhas in the treasure stūpa	Śākyamuni and Prabhūtaratna	In the *Lotus Sūtra*, Prabhūtaratna witnesses Śākyamuni's teaching. Their pairing makes truth-telling and reliable witness especially relevant to confession.
Western Pure Land triad	Amitābha with Avalokiteśvara and Mahāsthāmaprāpta	Amitābha's vows are joined with compassion and the strength of recollection. Scroll One's memorial rite names all three together in the Lotus Pool assembly.
The future Buddha	Maitreya as bodhisattva now and Buddha in the future	This explains why the source calls Maitreya “Buddha” while many profiles and artworks call Maitreya a bodhisattva.

These groupings are reading aids, not a claim that every temple image uses the same arrangement. The Medicine Master Buddha, Kṣitigarbha and other figures also have their own assemblies and iconographic traditions.

Principal Buddhas

Śākyamuni Buddha

Say it like: *SHAH-kyah-MOO-nee BOOD-uh*
Name meaning: Sage of the Śākya people
Recognise him: a monastic Buddha, often touching the earth with his right hand



Traditional life account: Śākyamuni is the historical teacher of our world. Born Siddhārtha Gautama in ancient India, he left a privileged life, trained with other seekers, rejected both indulgence and punishing self-denial, awakened beneath the bodhi tree and taught a path out of suffering. Buddhist texts tell this life as both the career of a human teacher and the fulfilment of a bodhisattva path cultivated over many lives.

Scroll One calls him “our teacher”. This distinguishes him from the many Buddhas of other ages and worlds invoked in the service. When the liturgy addresses all Buddhas and then returns to Śākyamuni, it moves from universal refuge to the teacher whose Dharma is available in this world.

Relationship and distinction: a statue in monastic robes with an earth-touching right hand often represents Śākyamuni's awakening. Monastic robes alone are not decisive because many Buddhas share them. In East Asian art, Mañjuśrī and Samantabhadra may attend him as wisdom and practice.

Why his name is invoked: to take refuge in the teacher who made the path known in this world.

Interesting fact: “Buddha” is a title, not a surname. Śākyamuni is also the seventh of the Seven Ancient Buddhas named in the liturgy.

Practice pathway: see suffering clearly, understand its causes and train in the path that ends them.

Source trail: *Water Repentance*, Scroll One, pp. 15-23; National Museum of Asian Art, Śākyamuni with Mañjuśrī and Samantabhadra.

Artwork: seventeenth-century Chinese bronze, National Museum in Warsaw. CC0 image via Wikimedia Commons.

Vairocana Buddha

Say it like: *vie-ROH-chah-nah BOOD-uh*
Name meaning: Illuminator, or the one who shines throughout
Recognise him: a central cosmic Buddha, sometimes forming a wisdom-fist hand gesture



Vairocana embodies the Dharma body, awakened reality and wisdom present without limit. He is especially important in the *Flower Adornment Sūtra* world of vast, interpenetrating Buddha-fields. This does not mean a creator standing outside the universe. Vairocana expresses Buddhahood as all-pervading illumination and the truth realised by awakened wisdom.

The universal offerings in Scroll One fit this vision: one flower becomes limitless offerings, and a single act is understood within the whole Dharma realm.

Why his name is invoked: to illuminate hidden motives and place personal reform within a reality larger than the individual.

Relationship and distinction: Vairocana and Śākyamuni are both Buddhas, but their emphases differ in this guide. Śākyamuni is "our teacher" in history; Vairocana presents awakened reality in its cosmic or Dharma-body dimension. A wisdom-fist gesture can identify Vairocana in some East Asian esoteric images, but Longmen and other traditions use different forms.

Interesting fact: Vairocana is often associated with Mañjuśrī and Samantabhadra. Wisdom and practice reveal the awakened reality he represents.

Practice pathway: bring confusion into the light, then let clear seeing reshape conduct.

Source trail: *Water Repentance*, Scroll One, pp. 19-23; Metropolitan Museum of Art, Buddha Vairocana and the wisdom-fist gesture.

Artwork: Vairocana at Longmen Grottoes, China. Mario Biondi, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons.

Amitābha Buddha

Say it like: *ah-mee-TAH-bhah BOOD-uh*
Name meaning: Infinite Light
Amitāyus: *ah-mee-TAH-yoos*, Infinite Life
Recognise him: seated in meditation or standing to welcome beings, often with Avalokiteśvara and Mahāsthāmaprāpta



Canonical account: Mahāyāna Pure Land scriptures tell that Amitābha was once the bodhisattva Dharmākara. He made forty-eight vows to establish Sukhāvatī, the Western Pure Land of Ultimate Bliss, as an exceptionally supportive place for awakening. These are vows to create conditions for liberation, not a promise that ethics and practice no longer matter.

Scroll One turns towards Amitābha in its dedication, Noon Offering and memorial rite. Recollection of his name gathers attention, while aspiration for the Pure Land directs practice towards non-retrogression and liberation. The memorial rite's Lotus Pool assembly places Amitābha with Avalokiteśvara and Mahāsthāmaprāpta.

Relationship and distinction: Amitābha means “Infinite Light” and Amitāyus means “Infinite Life”. The names are closely related and often refer to the same Buddha, although particular ritual and artistic traditions may emphasise one aspect. Sukhāvatī is a Buddha-field for continuing towards awakening, not simply a permanent heaven within the six realms.

Why his name is invoked: for mindful recollection, confidence in awakening, care for the deceased and aspiration to favourable conditions for practice.

Interesting fact: Amitābha and Amitāyus are two aspects of the same Buddha, emphasising infinite light and infinite life. “Guide and Receiver of the West” is also Amitābha.

Practice pathway: return a scattered mind to one wholesome direction, then include all beings in the aspiration.

Source trail: *Water Repentance*, Scroll One, pp. 51-64; Fo Guang Shan, *The Forty-Eight Vows of Amitabha Buddha*; Metropolitan Museum of Art, Amitābha triad.

Artwork: ninth-century painting of Amitābha with eight great bodhisattvas. Public domain via Wikimedia Commons.

Medicine Master Buddha

Say it like: *MED-ih-sin MAS-ter BOOD-uh*
Sanskrit: Bhaiṣajyaguru, approximately *bye-SHAJ-yah-GOO-roo*
Name meaning: Medicine Teacher
Recognise him: a Buddha holding a medicine bowl or medicinal plant, often blue in Tibetan art



Canonical account: the *Scripture of Master of Medicine, Beryl Radiance Tathāgata* presents twelve vows concerned with bodily and mental suffering, material need, ethical confusion and conditions supportive of the path. Healing in this tradition is broader than the promise of a cure. It includes relief from suffering, access to necessities, ethical direction and a life used well.

Scroll One invokes him during the Noon Offering as “disaster-eradicating and longevity-extending”. This is a traditional devotional title, not a substitute for medical care.

Relationship and distinction: Medicine Master is associated with an eastern pure land and is often accompanied by Sunlight and Moonlight bodhisattvas and twelve guardian generals. This differs from Amitābha's western Sukhāvatī and its familiar attendant pair. A bowl, staff or medicinal fruit may help identify him, while blue skin is characteristic of some Tibetan images rather than a universal rule.

Why his name is invoked: to support healing, protection and the conditions in which wisdom and compassion can grow.

Interesting fact: his full title links healing with lapis-lazuli radiance, a clear blue brilliance associated with purity.

Practice pathway: identify the cause of harm, apply a fitting remedy and use restored strength to help others.

Source trail: *Water Repentance*, Scroll One, p. 55; BDK America, *The Scripture of Master of Medicine, Beryl Radiance Tathāgata*; Metropolitan Museum of Art, Medicine Buddha mural.

Artwork: Chinese mural of Medicine Master Buddha and his assembly, about 1319, Metropolitan Museum of Art. Public domain.

Dīpaṃkara Buddha

Say it like: *dee-PUNG-kah-rah BOOD-uh* **Name meaning:** Maker of Light **Recognise him:** an ancient Buddha standing or seated in monastic robes, sometimes connected with lamps



Traditional account: the future Śākyamuni was an ascetic named Sumedha, or Sumati in some retellings. Seeing muddy ground before Dīpaṃkara, he spread his hair across it so the Buddha could pass. Dīpaṃkara then predicted that he would one day become Śākyamuni Buddha. The name and details vary across textual and regional traditions, while the central point remains the prediction of future Buddhahood.

Scroll Three invokes Dīpaṃkara in the opening lamp praise. The link between his name and light makes him a fitting figure for wisdom illuminating dark paths.

Relationship and distinction: Dīpaṃkara is a Buddha of the distant past; Maitreya is the Buddha expected in the future; Śākyamuni teaches in the present age. Together they make one act of repentance part of a path extending beyond a single lifetime. Lamps are a strong thematic link to Dīpaṃkara's name, but they are not a unique identifier in art.

Why his name is invoked: to recall long-term aspiration, humility and confidence that a vow can mature across an immense path.

Interesting fact: the meeting between Dīpaṃkara and Sumedha became a frequent subject in Buddhist art because it represents a future Buddha receiving confirmation of his path.

Practice pathway: make a sincere commitment now, even when its full result lies far beyond the present moment.

Source trail: *Water Repentance*, Scroll Three, p. 3; Norton Simon Museum, Dīpaṃkara Buddha; Metropolitan Museum of Art, Dīpaṃkara and Sumedha.

Artwork: Nepalese gilt image of Dīpaṃkara, about 1600-1650, Norton Simon Museum. CC0 image via Wikimedia Commons.

Maitreya

Say it like: *my-TRAY-yah*
Name meaning: the Loving or Friendly One
Recognise him: a princely bodhisattva, or in East Asia through the smiling monk Budai



Canonical account: Maitreya is the bodhisattva who will become the next Buddha in this world after Śākyamuni's teaching has disappeared. Canonical and later Buddhist sources place him in Tuṣita Heaven while he awaits his final birth and future awakening.

Scroll One calls him “future descending-birth, honoured Maitreya Buddha”, speaking from the perspective of his future awakening.

Relationship and distinction: “Maitreya Bodhisattva” describes his present role; “Maitreya Buddha” anticipates his future awakening. These are two stages associated with one figure, not two separate sacred beings.

Why his name is invoked: to cultivate loving-kindness, patience and confidence that the Dharma can appear again in difficult times.

Interesting fact: the familiar round-bellied smiling figure in many East Asian temples is Budai, a Chinese monk later regarded as a manifestation of Maitreya. Princely images with a water flask belong to an older Maitreya tradition, so the two forms can look completely different.

Practice pathway: let repentance open a constructive future rather than remain fixed on the past.

Source trail: *Water Repentance*, Scroll One, pp. 15-23 and 55; BDK America, *The Sutra That Expounds the Descent of Maitreya Buddha and His Enlightenment*; Metropolitan Museum of Art, Maitreya and Tuṣita; Metropolitan Museum of Art, Budai.

Artwork: fifteenth-century painting of Maitreya, Rubin Museum of Art. Public domain via Wikimedia Commons.

Prabhūtaratna Buddha

Say it like: *prah-BOO-tah-RUT-nah BOOD-uh*
Name meaning: Many Treasures
Recognise him: seated beside Śākyamuni inside or above a treasure stūpa



Canonical account: in Chapter 11 of the *Lotus Sūtra*, Prabhūtaratna's treasure stūpa rises from the earth wherever that teaching is proclaimed. He praises the teaching as true, invites Śākyamuni to share his seat and bears witness before the assembly.

Scroll One includes both the stūpa and Prabhūtaratna in its Samantabhadra visualisation and Buddha-name litany.

Relationship and distinction: paired Buddhas inside a stūpa commonly represent Prabhūtaratna and Śākyamuni. Prabhūtaratna is not the same figure as Dīpaṃkara, another Buddha of the past. In this guide, Dīpaṃkara points to the long maturation of a vow, while Prabhūtaratna points to witness and the continuity of true teaching.

Why his name is invoked: to place the practice before an awakened witness and affirm the continuity of the Dharma.

Interesting fact: East Asian images of two Buddhas seated together usually depict this scene, not two unrelated teachers.

Practice pathway: stop hiding the truth and make reform accountable before a worthy witness.

Source trail: *Water Repentance*, Scroll One, pp. 11-12 and 19-23; BDK America, *The Lotus Sutra*, Chapter 11, PDF pp. 183-190.

Artwork: Śākyamuni and Prabhūtaratna, China, dated 609. Gary Todd, CC0 via Wikimedia Commons.

Principal bodhisattvas

Avalokiteśvara Bodhisattva

Say it like: *ah-vah-loh-kee-TAYSH-vah-rah*
Common English or Chinese name: Guanyin, *gwahn-yin*
Name meaning: commonly understood in East Asia as the one who observes the cries of the world
Recognise this figure: a lotus, vase of pure water, willow branch, many arms, or a small Amitābha image in the crown



Canonical account: Avalokiteśvara embodies compassion that hears suffering and responds in whatever form can help. Chapter 25 of the *Lotus Sūtra* describes this responsiveness through many forms suited to different beings. In the *Heart Sūtra* recited during the memorial rite, this bodhisattva also embodies profound wisdom by seeing the five aggregates as empty.

Relationship and distinction: Guanyin is the Chinese name by which Avalokiteśvara is widely known. The small Amitābha image sometimes worn in the crown connects Guanyin with Amitābha's Pure Land. A vase and willow branch are common East Asian cues; a lotus and many-armed forms belong to other established forms. No single attribute appears in every image.

Why the name is invoked: for responsive compassion joined with insight.

Interesting fact: Indian images are often masculine. In China, Vietnam and other parts of East Asia, Guanyin is often represented in a feminine form. These are not separate bodhisattvas.

Practice pathway: listen fully before defending yourself, then respond in a way that actually reduces suffering.

Source trail: *Water Repentance*, Scroll One, pp. 19-23 and 59-64; Fo Guang Shan, *The Heart Sūtra*; BDK America, *The Lotus Sutra*, Chapter 25, PDF pp. 311-318; Metropolitan Museum of Art, Avalokiteśvara and Mahāsthāmaprāpta.

Artwork: Guanyin, China, late seventeenth to early eighteenth century, Metropolitan Museum of Art. Public domain.

Mañjuśrī Bodhisattva

Say it like: *mun-joo-SHREE*
Name meaning: Wondrous Glory or Wondrous Auspiciousness
Recognise this figure: a flaming sword, wisdom scripture, lotus or lion mount



Mañjuśrī embodies the wisdom that recognises emptiness and cuts through confused views. In Mahāyāna sūtras he often asks or answers the question that exposes the heart of a teaching. “Wisdom” here is insight into conditions, impermanence and emptiness, joined with the ability to choose a skilful response.

Relationship and distinction: Mañjuśrī and Samantabhadra often attend Śākyamuni as wisdom and practice. The pairing is useful in repentance: understanding why harm arose is incomplete until a corrective action follows, while determined action without clear understanding can repeat the same confusion.

Why the name is invoked: to understand the conditions behind harmful action and avoid mistaking shame for wisdom.

Interesting fact: the sword is not a weapon against people. It represents insight cutting through ignorance. The lion expresses the fearless voice of the Dharma.

Practice pathway: ask which assumption, story or misperception allowed the action to seem reasonable.

Source trail: *Water Repentance*, Scroll One, pp. 19-23 and 55; Metropolitan Museum of Art, Mañjuśrī's sword and wisdom text; National Museum of Asian Art, Śākyamuni with Mañjuśrī and Samantabhadra.

Artwork: traditional image of lion-riding Mañjuśrī. Public domain via Wikimedia Commons.

Samantabhadra Bodhisattva

Say it like: *sah-MUN-tah-BHAD-rah*
Name meaning: Universal Worthy or All-encompassing Good
Recognise this figure: a white elephant, often with six tusks



Traditional practice account: Samantabhadra embodies vows carried into practice. His ten great vows include homage, praise, offering, repentance, rejoicing in goodness, requesting the teaching, asking Buddhas to remain, learning, helping beings and dedicating merit. Several of these actions structure the Water Repentance itself.

Scroll One gives him its richest visualisation. The practitioner imagines Samantabhadra seated on a lotus, filling the Dharma realm with light and offerings, and then invokes him again at major transitions. The visualisation expands a physically limited offering into an intention directed towards all beings.

Relationship and distinction: Mañjuśrī represents insight and Samantabhadra represents its enactment. The white elephant and six tusks are common East Asian recognition cues. Fo Guang Shan reads the six tusks as the six perfections, although artistic details differ and an elephant alone does not prove an image's identity.

Why the name is invoked: to turn remorse into sustained compassionate conduct.

Interesting fact: Fo Guang Shan explains the six tusks as the six perfections. The white elephant joins purity with strong, steady movement.

Practice pathway: make the next wholesome action specific enough to perform and repeat.

Source trail: *Water Repentance*, Scroll One, pp. 11-15 and 55; Fo Guang Shan, Samantabhadra Bodhisattva Shrine; National Museum of Asian Art, Śākyamuni with Mañjuśrī and Samantabhadra.

Artwork: Samantabhadra riding an elephant, China, twelfth to fourteenth century, Metropolitan Museum of Art. Public domain.

Mahāsthāmaprāpta Bodhisattva

Say it like: *mah-HAH-stah-mah-PRAHP-tah*
Name meaning: Arrival of Great Strength
Recognise this figure: beside Amitābha, often with a water-vase emblem in the crown



Mahāsthāmaprāpta represents the strength of wisdom, concentration and continuous recollection. Along with Avalokiteśvara, this bodhisattva attends Amitābha in the familiar Western Pure Land triad.

Relationship and distinction: Avalokiteśvara expresses responsive compassion; Mahāsthāmaprāpta expresses the strength that keeps recollection and aspiration steady. In some East Asian images, Avalokiteśvara has a small Amitābha in the crown and Mahāsthāmaprāpta has a vase emblem. Position alone is unreliable because arrangements can reverse or vary.

In Scroll One's memorial rite, the three sit together on lotus thrones. Their grouping joins the destination of practice, compassionate response and the collected strength needed to continue.

Why the name is invoked: to gather a scattered mind and sustain wholesome recollection.

Interesting fact: the “great strength” is not domination. It is the power of a mind no longer pulled in every direction.

Practice pathway: choose a wholesome recollection and return to it until it becomes stronger than the old reaction.

Source trail: *Water Repentance*, Scroll One, pp. 55-64; Metropolitan Museum of Art, Amitābha triad; Metropolitan Museum of Art, Avalokiteśvara and Mahāsthāmaprāpta.

Artwork: Mahāsthāmaprāpta, China, late seventeenth to early eighteenth century, Metropolitan Museum of Art. Public domain.

Kṣitigarbha Bodhisattva

Say it like: *kshih-tee-GAHR-bhah*
Name meaning: Earth Treasury
Recognise this figure: a monastic with a staff and wish-fulfilling jewel



Canonical account: Kṣitigarbha is renowned for immense vows to help beings in the hells and other states of severe suffering. The *Sūtra on the Past Vows of Kṣitigarbha Bodhisattva* tells of earlier lives in which filial concern for a suffering mother expands into a vow to liberate all suffering beings. This makes the figure especially relevant to memorial dedication without limiting the compassion to one's own family.

Reading note: the popular formula “until the hells are empty, I vow not to become a Buddha” accurately expresses the tradition's ideal, but the 2026 BDK translation notes that this exact sentence does not appear in the sūtra. The guide therefore presents it as a traditional summary rather than a direct quotation.

Relationship and distinction: Kṣitigarbha often appears in monastic robes with a ringed staff and wish-fulfilling jewel. This is unusual among major bodhisattvas, who are often shown in princely dress. The Water Repentance's long accounts of painful realms make his refusal to abandon beings there directly relevant to its movement from remorse to universal care.

Why the name is invoked: to extend responsibility and compassion to beings who seem most difficult to reach.

Interesting fact: unlike princely bodhisattvas covered in jewels, Kṣitigarbha often appears as a simple monastic. The image suggests closeness to places of suffering.

Practice pathway: do not abandon the person or situation merely because help will be slow and difficult.

Source trail: *Water Repentance*, Scroll One, pp. 19-23 and 55; BDK America, *Sūtra on the Past Vows of Ksitigarbha Bodhisattva*, introduction at PDF pp. 56-58 and vow narrative at pp. 67-71; Metropolitan Museum of Art, Ksitigarbha as a monastic with staff and jewel.

Artwork: Kṣitigarbha, Korea, first half of the fourteenth century, Metropolitan Museum of Art. Public domain.

Mahāvyūha Bodhisattva

Say it like: *mah-HAH-VYOO-hah*
Name meaning: Great Adornment or Great Array



Scroll One includes Mahāvyūha in its repeated bodhisattva litany, as do Scrolls Two and Three, but the English source gives no independent story or identifying attributes. “Great Adornment” and “Great Array” are cautious ways to read the Sanskrit components of the name. They are reading aids, not a secure biography.

No securely standard portrait has been identified for this figure. The symbolic lotus avoids mislabelling a generic image. The practice pathway below is an application of the name's possible sense, not a claim that the liturgy supplies a separate Mahāvyūha teaching.

Practice pathway: adorn life through conduct rather than appearance alone.

Source trail: *Water Repentance*, Scroll One, pp. 19-23; Scroll Two, pp. 4-8; Scroll Three, pp. 4-7. No separate iconographic source is asserted.

The Seven Ancient Buddhas



Scroll One invokes a traditional succession of seven Buddhas. The first three belong to a previous world age. The final four, ending with Śākyamuni, belong to the present fortunate age. Their recitation places one act of repentance within a long continuity of awakening.

An early Buddhist discourse preserved in Sanskrit and related traditions names the same sequence. The Water Repentance then names Maitreya separately as the future Buddha. Maitreya is therefore not an eighth member of this particular "Seven Ancient Buddhas" set.

Buddha	Say it like	Note
Vipaśyin	*vih-PUSH-yin*	Often understood as Clear-Seeing.
Śikhin	*SHEE-kin*	A past Buddha, not Śikhin Brahmā.
Viśvabhū	*VISH-vah-BOO*	A Buddha of an earlier world age.
Krakucchanda	*krah-koot-CHUN-dah*	First Buddha of the present fortunate age.
Kanakamuni	*kah-nah-kah-MOO-nee*	Second Buddha of the present fortunate age.
Kāśyapa Buddha	*KAH-shyah-pah*	Buddha immediately before Śākyamuni, not the disciple Mahākāśyapa.
Śākyamuni	*SHAH-kyah-MOO-nee*	The historical teacher of our world.

Why the seven are invoked: the liturgy confesses before a succession of awakened teachers rather than treating purification as a private invention. The repeated Seven Buddhas Offence-Extinguishing Mantra later gathers that continuity into a short closing chant. The title gives the secure ritual purpose; the transmitted syllables should not be turned into an invented word-for-word translation.

Recognition limit: sets of seven Buddha images may represent this succession, but unlabelled figures can look almost identical. Sequence, inscriptions and collection records are more dependable than guessing from robe or hand gesture alone.

Source trail: *Water Repentance*, Scroll One, pp. 15-18 and 51; SuttaCentral, *Mahāvadāna*, "The Characteristics of the Seven Buddhas".

Artwork: Chinese sculpture of the Seven Buddhas, Tang to Five Dynasties period. CC0 via Wikimedia Commons.

Buddhas in the repeated litany

The source names several Buddhas without giving stories or distinctive iconography. Their liturgical purpose is clear: they form an awakened assembly before whom confession and vows are made. A long translated title can evoke wisdom, sovereignty, a lotus, a monastic robe or a lion's roar without giving enough evidence for a separate life story or portrait. The guide therefore explains recognisable name elements and does not invent biographies.

Name	Easy pronunciation	Secure beginner note
Nāgagotrodārajñānarāja	*NAH-gah-goh-troh-DAH-rah-NYAH-nah-RAH-jah*	A Buddha whose long title is associated with a noble dragon or nāga lineage and wisdom.
Nāgeśvararāja	*nah-GAYSH-vah-rah-RAH-jah*	“Sovereign King of Nāgas” or “Dragon Sovereign King”.
Buddhapuṇḍarīkadhyaneśvararāja	*BOOD-dhah-poon-dah-REE-kah-DYAH-nay-shvah-rah-RAH-jah*	A title joining the awakening lotus, meditation and sovereign mastery.
Kasayadhvaja	*kah-SAH-yah-dvah-jah*	“Banner of the monastic robe”, an image of renunciation and the Dharma made visible.
Siṃhanāda	*SING-hah-NAH-dah*	“Lion's Roar”, an image of fearless Dharma teaching.

These names are easiest to use as part of the litany's movement: bow, acknowledge the awakened witness, confess, and make the answering vow. For pronunciation, accuracy means a calm, recognisable reading and following the officiant rather than mastering every compound before participating.

Ritual and collective invocations

Some titles sound like individual people but function more naturally as invocations of an image, quality or assembly.

Invocation	Meaning in context
Incense Cloud Canopy Bodhisattva-Mahāsattvas	The fragrant offering imagined as a vast canopy reaching awakened assemblies.
Precious Uḍumbara Blossom Bodhisattva-Mahāsattvas	An auspicious blossom famous in Buddhist literature for rarity, used here in an offering and homage context. No secure individual biography is supplied.
Equal Awakening Stage Bodhisattva-Mahāsattvas	Advanced bodhisattvas at the stage immediately preceding complete Buddhahood.
Pure Cool Ground Bodhisattva-Mahāsattvas	A memorial invocation of purity and relief from the “heat” of affliction.
Dhyāna Bliss Treasury Bodhisattva-Mahāsattvas	A personified image of the deep joy and ease associated with meditation.
Sanghārāma Bodhisattvas	Protectors of monasteries and Buddhist practice places.

The plural **bodhisattva-mahāsattvas** in these invocations is significant. It supports reading them as assemblies or personified ritual qualities unless a reliable source identifies an individual figure. This is why the guide provides no invented costume, life story or portrait for them.

Source trail: *Water Repentance*, Scroll One, pp. 7, 15, 51, 56, 58 and 59. These are the source locations of the six invocations listed above.

References

Sources and artwork records

The original reference set was checked on 24 August 2026. Sources added for the expanded figure profiles and reading aids were checked on 27 September 2026. This does not claim that every earlier external link was rechecked on the later date. The guide paraphrases its copyrighted source and uses short labels only where necessary for explanation.

Source liturgy

- Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple. *Liturgy of the Samādhi Water Repentance of Kindness and Compassion: Scroll One*. Electronic edition 3.0, 2022. Main source for the Scroll One guide and page map.
- Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple. *Scroll Two*. Electronic edition 3.0, 2022. Main source for the Scroll Two guide and page map.
- Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple. *Scroll Three*. Electronic edition 3.0, 2022. Main source for the Scroll Three guide, memorial rites and final prayer.

The PDFs credit Andrew Nguy and Raymond Kong as translators, editors and graphic designers. They state that reproduction requires the publisher's permission except for fair use. The original PDFs are therefore not included in this repository.

Fo Guang Shan and Hsi Lai Temple resources

- Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center. Buddhist Glossary. Primary terminology cross-check.
- Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center. *The Heart Sūtra*. Five aggregates, emptiness and Avalokiteśvara.
- Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center. *The Amitabha Sutra*. Amitābha, Sukhāvatī and Pure Land practice.
- Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center. *The Forty-Eight Vows of Amitabha Buddha*. Dharmākara's vows and Pure Land aspiration.
- Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center. *Starting a Daily Practice*. Amitābha name-recitation, Pure Land aspiration and the image of rebirth on a lotus.
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- Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center. *Visiting a Buddhist Temple*. Temple etiquette and ritual actions.
- Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center. *The Buddhist Perspective on Life and Destiny*. Karma, repentance and the image of Dharma water.
- Fo Guang Shan. Samantabhadra Bodhisattva Shrine. White elephant, six tusks, vows and practice.
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Terminology and language sources

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Canonical and translation sources

- BDK America. *The Mahayana Sutra of Previous Lives and Contemplation of the Mind-ground*. Confession, shame, vows and repentance at phenomenal and principle levels.
- BDK America. *A Forest of Pearls from the Dharma Garden*, volume 1. Traditional cosmology and six-realm context.
- BDK America. *The Lotus Sutra*, revised second edition. Prabhūtaratna and the jewelled stūpa in Chapter 11; Avalokiteśvara's responsive forms in Chapter 25.

- BDK America. *The Scripture of Master of Medicine, Beryl Radiance Tathāgata*. Medicine Master Buddha's twelve vows and devotional role.
- BDK America. *The Sutra That Expounds the Descent of Maitreya Buddha and His Enlightenment*. Maitreya as the future Buddha who appears after the decline of Śākyamuni's teaching.
- BDK America. *Sūtra on the Past Vows of Kṣitigarbha Bodhisattva*. Kṣitigarbha's vow narratives, filial setting and universal compassion. The translator's introduction also distinguishes the popular summary vow from the scripture's exact wording.
- 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha. *The Dhāraṇī "Essence of Immeasurable Longevity and Wisdom"*. A canonical example linking recitation of Amitābha's name with Sukhāvatī and lotus birth rather than gestation in a womb.
- SuttaCentral. Aṅguttara Nikāya 6.63, *Penetrative*. Early Buddhist definition of karma through intention.
- SuttaCentral. Saṃyutta Nikāya 12.2, *Analysis of Dependent Origination*. The twelve links.
- SuttaCentral. Sanskrit fragment of the *Mahāvadāna*, "The Characteristics of the Seven Buddhas". The succession of Vipaśyin, Śikhin, Viśvabhū, Krakucchanda, Kanakamuni, Kāśyapa and Śākyamuni.

Later Pure Land teaching used with a clear label

- Amitabha Buddhist Society. *Pure Mind, Compassionate Heart: Lessons from the Amitabha Sutra*, p. 91. Source for the later devotional image of a lotus associated with the practitioner and described as bearing the practitioner's name. The companion does not present this detail as wording from the Water Repentance or the shorter *Amitābha Sūtra*.

Historical and academic studies

- De Hong. *A Study and Translation of The Compassionate Water Repentance Ritual*. University of the West, 2011. Main historical study used for the development of the ritual, uncertain authorship, traditional Wuda narrative, and phenomenal and principle repentance.
- Wendi L. Adamek. "Addressing the Mind: Developments in the Culture of Confession in Sui-Tang China". *Journal of Chinese Buddhist Studies* 28, 2015, pp. 117-152. Chinese Buddhist confession and repentance context.
- Sun He-Rong. "A Study on the Purification of Defilements in The Compassion-Samadhi-Water-Repentance". Nanhua University, 2024. Modern study of the first scroll's defilement lists and practice.
- Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy. Japanese Pure Land Philosophy. Used cautiously for the broader doctrinal distinction between Pure Land aspiration and ordinary saṃsāric heaven. The companion does not treat the Chinese liturgy as a Japanese sectarian text.

Figure relationships and recognition

These museum and institutional records support the profile's visual cues and relationship notes. They do not imply that every regional image uses the same attributes.

- National Museum of Asian Art. *The Buddha Shakyamuni with the Bodhisattvas Samantabhadra and Manjushri*. Śākyamuni's East Asian grouping with wisdom and practice.
- The Metropolitan Museum of Art. *Amitabha triad* and stele with Avalokiteśvara and Mahāsthāmaprāpta. The Western Pure Land triad and crown emblems.
- The Metropolitan Museum of Art. Buddha Vairocana. The wisdom-fist gesture in one East Asian esoteric form.
- The Metropolitan Museum of Art. Buddha of Medicine mural. Medicine Master with Sunlight and Moonlight bodhisattvas and twelve guardians.
- The Metropolitan Museum of Art. Mañjuśrī and Kṣitigarbha. The wisdom sword and text; the monastic robe, staff and jewel.
- The Metropolitan Museum of Art. Gandharan Maitreya and Budai. Maitreya in Tuṣita and the later East Asian identification of the laughing monk Budai with Maitreya.

- Norton Simon Museum. Dīpamkara Buddha; and The Metropolitan Museum of Art, Dīpamkara and Sumedha. Museum summaries of the traditional prediction story and variations in the bodhisattva's name.

Artwork records

Each image caption in FIGURES.md gives its direct museum or Wikimedia source and licence. Key collection records include:

- The Metropolitan Museum of Art: Avalokiteśvara, Samantabhadra, Mahāsthāmaprāpta and Kṣitigarbha.
- Wikimedia Commons: Śākyamuni, Vairocana, Amitābha, Dīpamkara, Maitreya, Medicine Master Buddha, Prabhūtaratna and Śākyamuni and the Seven Buddhas.

Editorial limits

- Sanskrit names and terms are normalised only where the identification is secure. The source spelling remains the reference for chanting.
- English pronunciation cues are approximations, not International Phonetic Alphabet transcriptions. In communal chanting, the officiant and the source's pinyin rhythm take priority.
- Mantra words are translated only where the Sanskrit sense is reasonably secure. Transmitted syllables with uncertain grammar are explained by ritual function rather than assigned an invented literal meaning.
- Lotus birth is distinguished from the later devotional image of a name-bearing lotus. The former is widely attested in Pure Land sources; the latter is presented as a teaching image, not as a sentence from the source liturgy.
- Vietnamese names are a recognition aid only. Tone and regional pronunciation should be learned from a Vietnamese speaker or temple.
- Literal and psychological interpretations of cosmological realms are both identified as recognised approaches. The guide does not claim that all Buddhist traditions interpret them in the same way.
- The traditional Wuda narrative is explained respectfully and distinguished from historical verification.

May the benefit of this work support understanding, compassionate reform and the awakening of all beings.